

Zookbert “Zook” Nackle

Male Rock Gnome, 81 years old.

The Lost Childhood

Most gnomes remember their childhoods as a chaotic symphony of learning, laughter, and minor explosions. Zook does not. His earliest memories are not of the warm warrens of his clan, but of the cold iron of a cage and the rough hands of slavers. The Nackle clan, known for their clever gem-cutting techniques, were traveling between mountain outposts when their caravan was ambushed. Young Zookbert, barely a decade old, was separated in the fray and snatched up. He never saw his parents again. He was just another piece of valuable, exotic cargo.

At the slave market in a sprawling human city, the small, terrified gnome drew the eye of a man named Elias Valerius. Valerius was not a warrior or a nobleman, but a master clockmaker whose eyesight was beginning to fail him. He saw Zook's small, nimble fingers and the sharp, assessing intelligence in his eyes and knew the boy would be perfect for the delicate work his own hands could no longer manage.

The Gilded Cage

Life with Master Valerius was a strange prison. The workshop was a wonderland of brass gears, shimmering crystals, and the constant, soothing symphony of a thousand ticking clocks. Zook was fed, clothed, and never beaten. But the collar around his neck, a simple, unadorned leather band, was a constant reminder of his station. Valerius was not cruel, but he was a businessman. Zook was his property, an investment.

Initially, Zook's duties were menial: sweeping brass shavings, polishing clock faces, and organizing tiny screws. But Zook didn't just clean; he watched. He absorbed. He saw the way a spring's tension translated into the steady sweep of a second hand. He memorized the intricate dance of the escapement mechanism. Valerius, recognizing the gnome's silent, intense curiosity, decided his investment would yield greater returns with training. He began teaching Zook the craft, first how to assemble, then how to craft, and finally, how to design.

The Master's Apprentice

Zook's aptitude was nothing short of genius. His small hands and innate gnomish understanding of complex systems made him a natural. Within two decades, he had surpassed his master. Valerius handled the customers and the business, but Zook was the heart of the workshop. His creations were masterpieces of precision, sought after by nobles and wealthy merchants.

His passion grew beyond clocks. He began tinkering in his small attic room after hours, using discarded scraps to create marvels: tiny clockwork birds that sang tinny melodies, intricate puzzle boxes with hidden compartments, and self-propelling toys. Each creation was a small act of defiance, a piece of himself that Valerius didn't own. As his skill grew, so did his value. Valerius would often boast to clients of his "gnome prodigy," a statement that filled Zook with both pride in his work and the bitter shame of his enslavement.

The Fatal Spark of Freedom

Decades passed in the steady rhythm of ticking and tinkering. On his eightieth birthday, a significant milestone for a young adult gnome, something fractured. Valerius presented him with a new, complex commission from a local baron. "Your work will make me a legend, little one," Valerius said, patting him on the head. In that moment, Zook saw a man who had stolen seventy years of his life and planned to take the rest. He would not spend another birthday as a tool.

He planned his escape meticulously. A tiny, acid-filled vial to weaken his window hinge. A multi-pronged lockpick disguised as a winding key. And the centerpiece: a complex, timed noisemaker to be placed in the main workshop, designed to create a loud, clattering diversion.

The night of the escape, the plan went into motion. The device in the workshop clattered to life, a cacophony of ringing bells and snapping gears. But Valerius was shrewder than Zook had anticipated. Hearing the noise, he didn't rush to the workshop; his first thought was to secure his most valuable asset. He stormed directly to Zook's attic room.

He burst in just as Zook, having slipped through the weakened window frame, was perched on the steep roof outside. "Boy! What is the meaning of this?!" Valerius shouted, his face a mask of shock and betrayal. He lunged through the window to grab Zook.

Pure, animal panic surged through the gnome. Zook didn't think; he reacted. He shoved his master away with all his might. Caught off-balance and half-out the window, the elderly Valerius stumbled backward. He flailed for a handhold, his eyes wide with terror, and then fell from the window ledge. The fall wasn't far, but the sickening crunch of his head striking the cobblestones of the alley below echoed in the night.

Zook froze, his heart hammering against his ribs. Peering down, he saw his master's still, broken form in the moonlight. Freedom had come, but its price was a life. He didn't flee in triumph. He fled in horror, scrambling across the rooftops with the sound of the fall replaying in his mind, the tools in his pocket suddenly feeling impossibly heavy.

A New, Unwinding World

Zook is now a free gnome, but his freedom is tainted by guilt and fear. In the eyes of the law, he is not just an escaped slave; he is a murderer. The bounty on his head will be for a killer, not just for stolen property. He is haunted by the image of Valerius's shocked face and the sound of his last moments. He is terrified that his own creations, his own hands, can bring such ruin.

He now wanders, a fugitive from the law and from his own memory. He seeks the meaning of freedom, but also a way to atone for the death he caused. He is desperate to prove, if only to himself, that he is a builder, not a destroyer.

From One Cage to Another

Zook's newfound freedom was a nightmare. The skills to craft a perfect chronometer were useless for finding food or shelter. Every shadow seemed to hold a bounty hunter; every stranger's face was a mask of suspicion. He was a fugitive, but more than that, he was an institutionalized creature, completely unequipped to survive on his own. Trapped in the city with no allies and no way to reach the distant mountains of his clan, his flight from the law was desperate, clumsy, and short.

He was apprehended by the city guard within a week, gaunt and shivering in a forgotten alley. The trial was a farce that lasted mere minutes. The verdict was a foregone conclusion, the judge's voice dripping with disdain, "The property is found guilty of the destruction of its master, Elias Valerius. The life of a slave is forfeit."

As the guards prepared to drag him to the regional dungeons to await a brutal end, a new figure intervened. A woman in the polished steel plate and white robes of the Church of Azeria stepped forward, her presence commanding silence in the courtroom. She was an Inquisitor of the faith, a militant order dedicated to order, industry, and the destruction of heresy.

"A murderer's life is indeed forfeit," the Inquisitor declared, her voice cutting through the air. "But talent is a gift from the Divine. It is a waste, and therefore a sin, to let such skill rot in a cell."

She produced a writ, stamped with the gear-and-sunburst seal of her office, invoking the "Right of Conscription." Under church law, assets vital to the holy war against chaos and heresy could be seized for the good of the faith. Zook was not to be executed. He was conscripted.

Instead of being thrown in a dungeon, Zook was taken to a church scriptorium, where the leather collar of the slave was replaced by the cold steel of a holy symbol, branded onto his skin like a rancher's mark. He was no longer Valerius's property, nor was he free. He was now an instrument of the Church of Azeria, his life spared only so his hands could serve their will. He is now tasked with building and maintaining the tools of the holy war—crafting specialized weapons, fortifying church strongholds, and repairing holy relics—all in the service of fighting heretics and any who oppose the rigid, unyielding will of the Church. He is a prisoner once more, just in a much larger, more dangerous cage.